The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

CAMPUS & COMMUNITY COALITION

Alcohol and Polysubstance Use in Chapel Hill

Qualitative Research Findings and Recommendations

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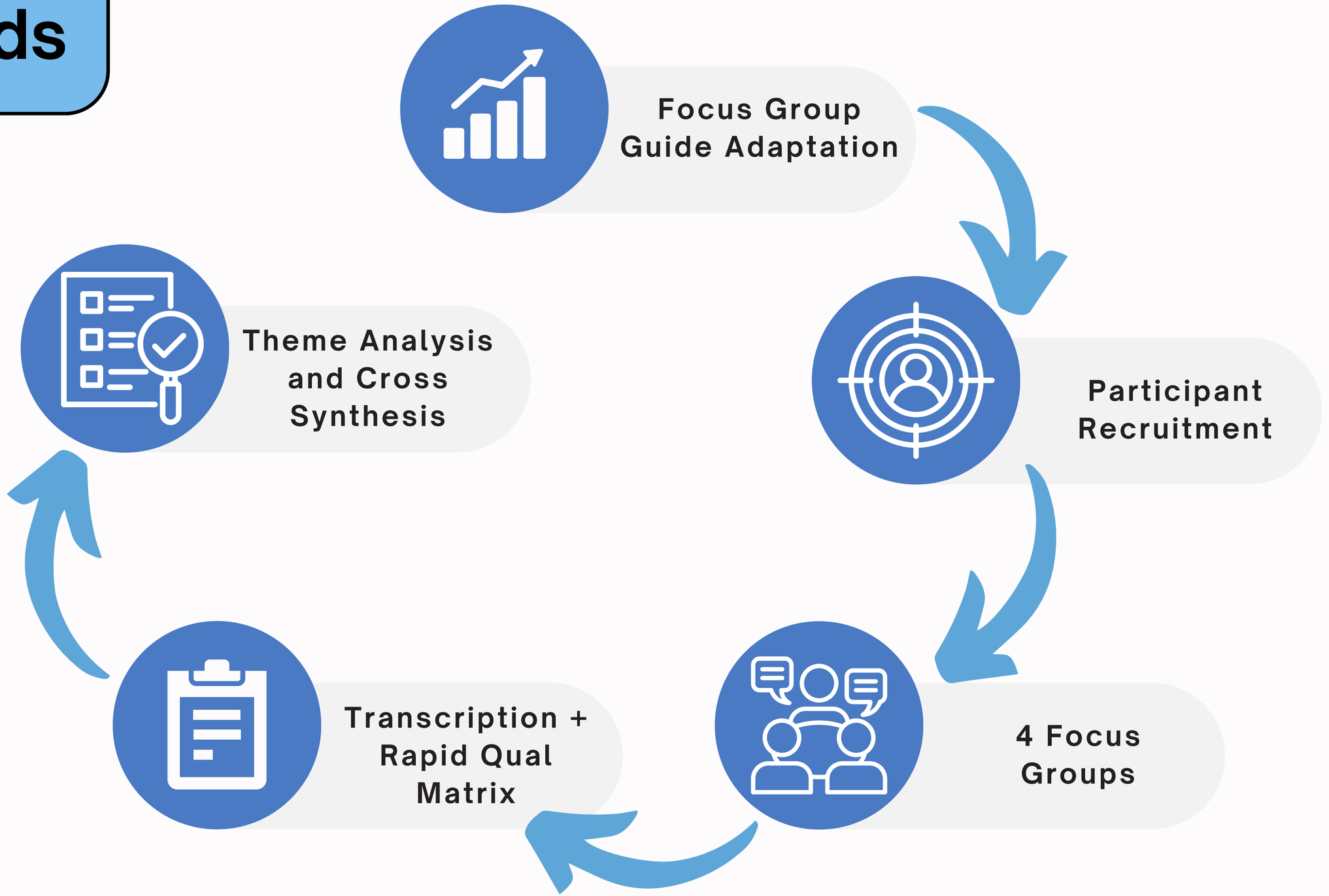
Purpose

Understand student perceptions and experiences with alcohol and polysubstance use

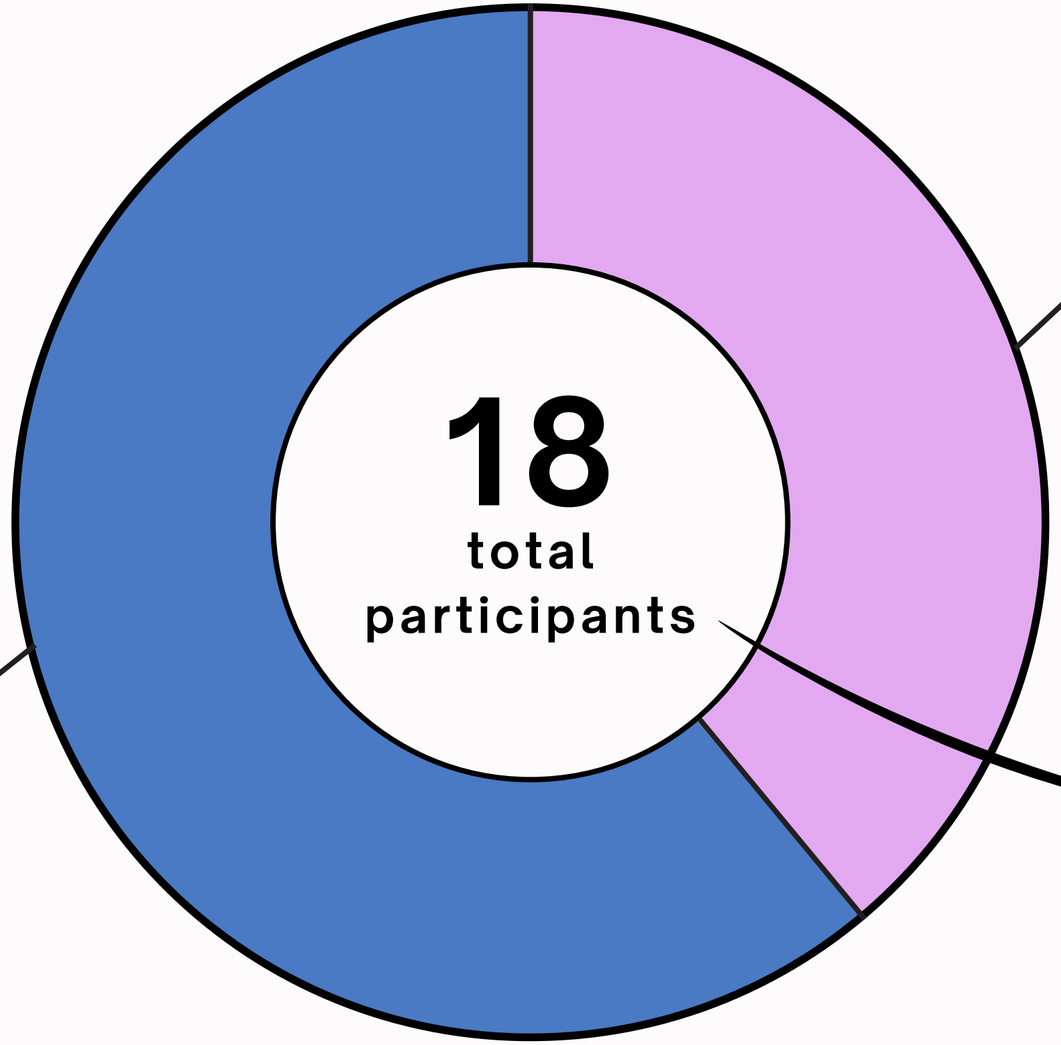
Identify key drivers and assess gaps in prevention

Recommend CCC actionable, student-centered approaches

Methods


Focus Group Guide Adaptation
Participant Recruitment
4 Focus Groups
Transcription + Rapid Qual Matrix
Theme Analysis and Cross Synthesis

4 Focus Group Discussions

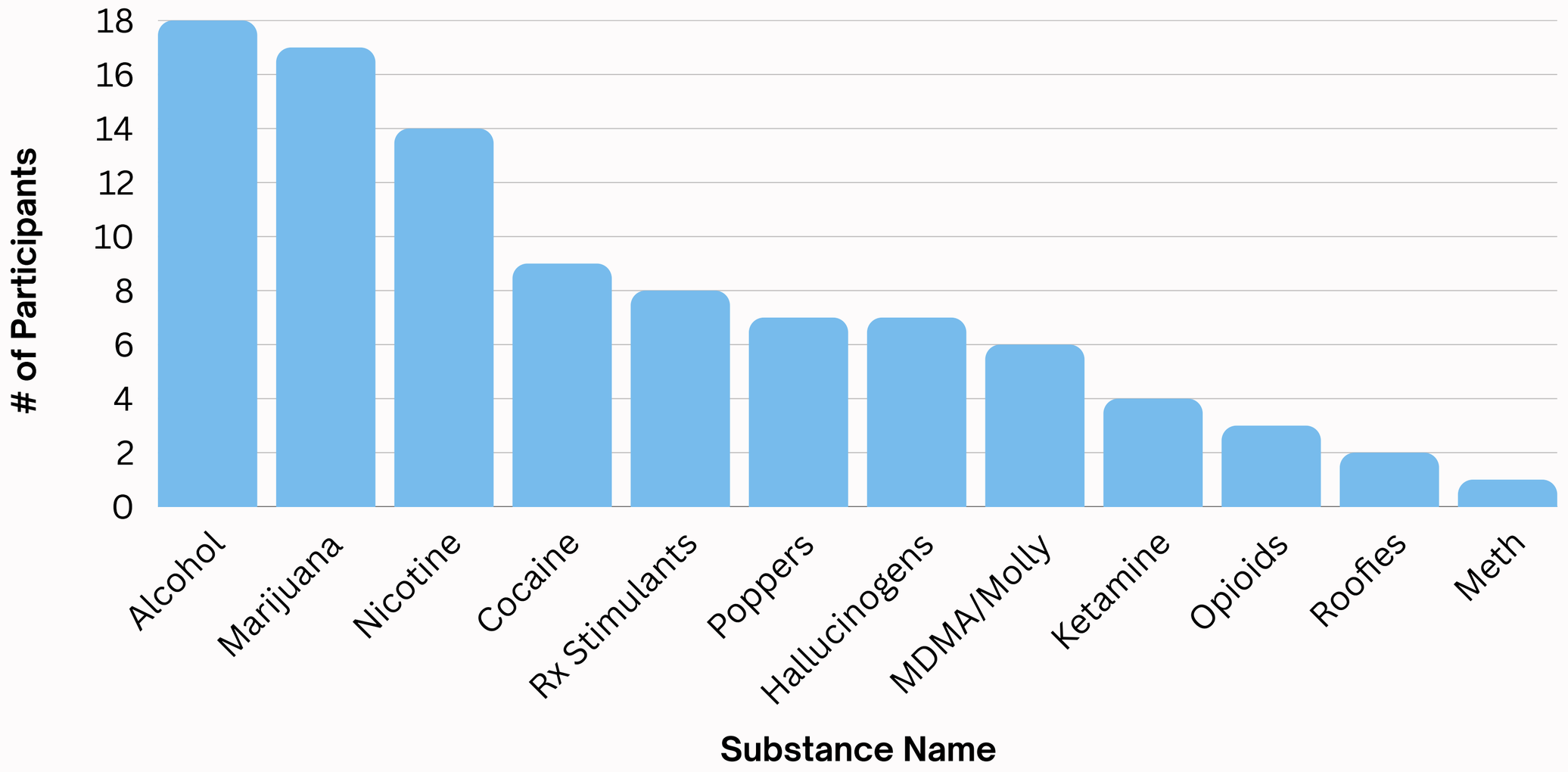


7
undergraduate students

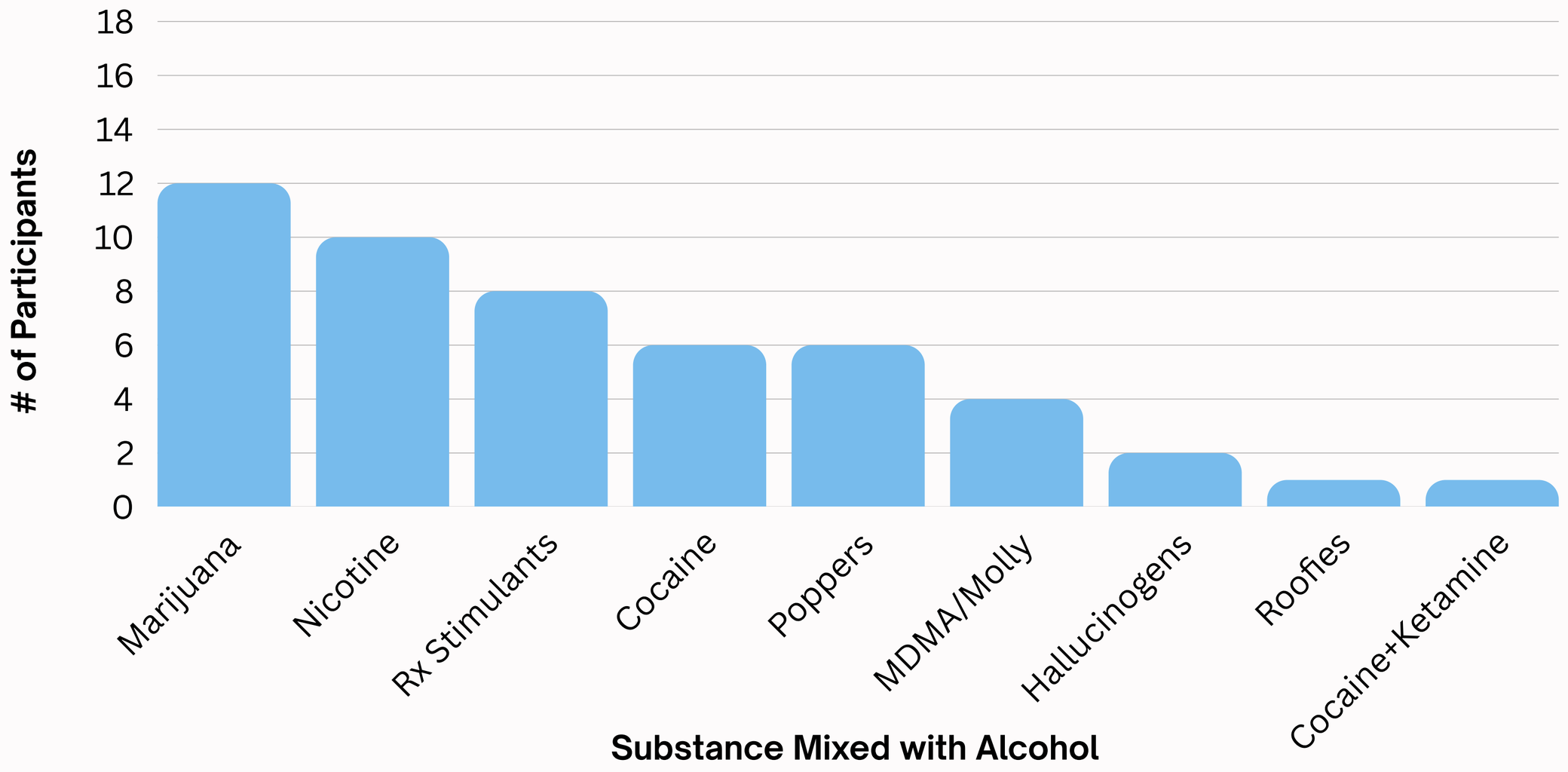
11
graduate students

across
10
areas of study

Participant References to Specific Substances



Participant References to Substances Mixed with Alcohol



Thematic Findings Summary

Student alcohol and substance use perceptions are shaped by social environments, norms, and culture. Decisions around use are influenced by stress, peers, and access. While harm reduction strategies exist, they are often inconsistently used, or limited by stigma and a lack of practical education. Our findings highlight the need to shift both institutional and peer norms to better support safety around polysubstance use among UNC students.



THEME 1

Social identity and context shape substance use norms



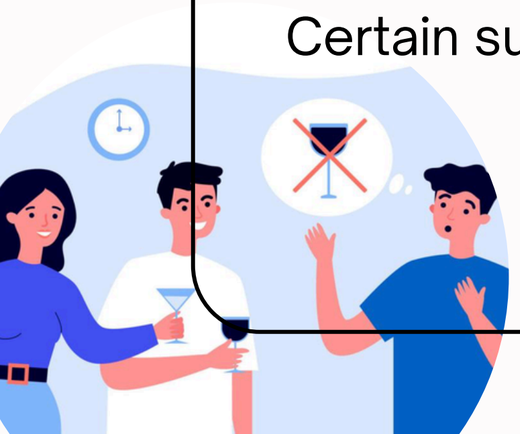
Theme 1

Substance use behaviors are shaped by social environments and group norms, which influence what is perceived as normal, expected, and rewarded.

Cultural and regional backgrounds influence early exposure and expectations

Social groups (e.g., Greek life, queer spaces, friend circles) shape norms and behaviors

Certain substances are tied to identity and status (e.g., cocaine in fraternity culture)

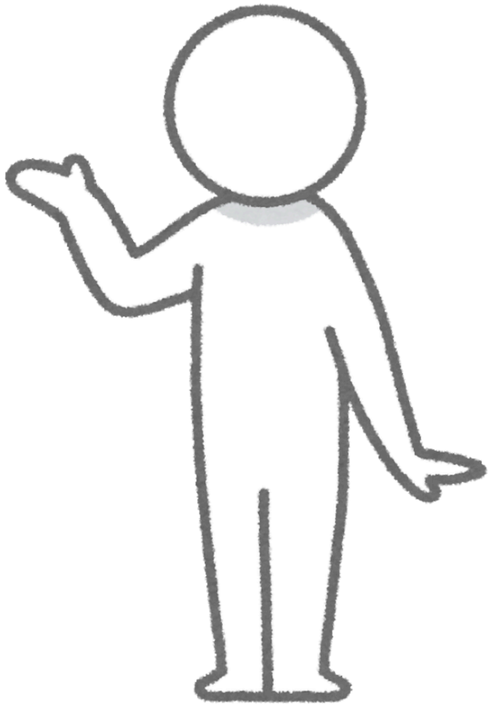


Use is often seen as a “rite of passage” into college life

"Drinking age is 18, but your parents started giving you alcohol a lot before. I'm from **Colombia**, so... like they were all **offering [alcohol] since I was 15.**"

"I know in queer spaces, poppers are very popular."

"It felt like a **rite of passage...** like this is how you show you're grown."



"When I think of **cocaine, frat brothers,** I think of finance, business, you know, things like that. Versus **marijuana, I think of social psychology, philosophy...**"



THEME 2

Social dynamics and access drive substance use and escalation



Theme 2

Substance use is driven by stress, enabled by access, reinforced by peers, and escalated by alcohol, particularly in social settings.

Substances are often accessed through friends and social networks

Peer pressure (especially internal) influences participation

Group size matter, pressure increases in mid-size groups

Stress and mental health drive use as a coping mechanism

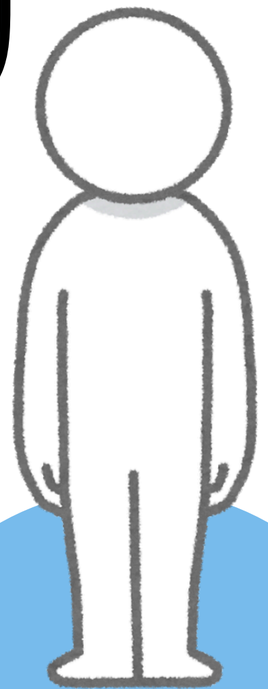
Alcohol lowers inhibitions and increases risk-taking and mixing substances



“My friend took edibles freshman year because they didn’t want to do it alone, and later said, ‘**I didn’t even want to—I just didn’t want to hurt her feelings**.’ That’s where I’ve seen the most pressure. **No one wants to be the only one not participating.”**

“If it's been a particularly stressful week for me, I'll drink because, you know, **it’ll take the edge off** or whatever.”

“*It’s like, a* **feeling that people are chasing**, *not as much, like, the actual substances.*”



“Being around other people who are doing it made me, from **my own personal internal perception, feel uncomfortable if I wasn't** doing it, which then turned into itching to do it.”



THEME 3

Harm reduction and safety strategies shape risk outcomes



Theme 3

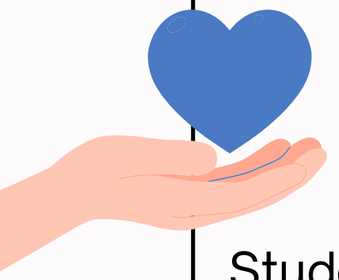
Students actively use harm reduction strategies, but inconsistent application, limited education, and stigma reduce their effectiveness.

Students rely mostly on peer-based safety strategies (“go together, leave together”)

Policies like Good Samaritan and Carpe Diem program support help-seeking over punishment

Harm reduction is practiced, but inconsistently applied

Students want honest, non-judgmental education, that can be applied, not just “don’t do it”



“We have a shared community... a shared sense of identity... so **no matter what I'm going to... make sure he's okay.**”

“Use and abuse is going to happen on campus... and **it needs to be addressed,** rather than just strictly forbidden and turning a blind eye to it.”

“The P2P... runs straight from Franklin to South Campus... which is where most freshmen stay... that’s a good way.”

“It never educates about... how to be safe. Practicing safe habits... those types of things.”

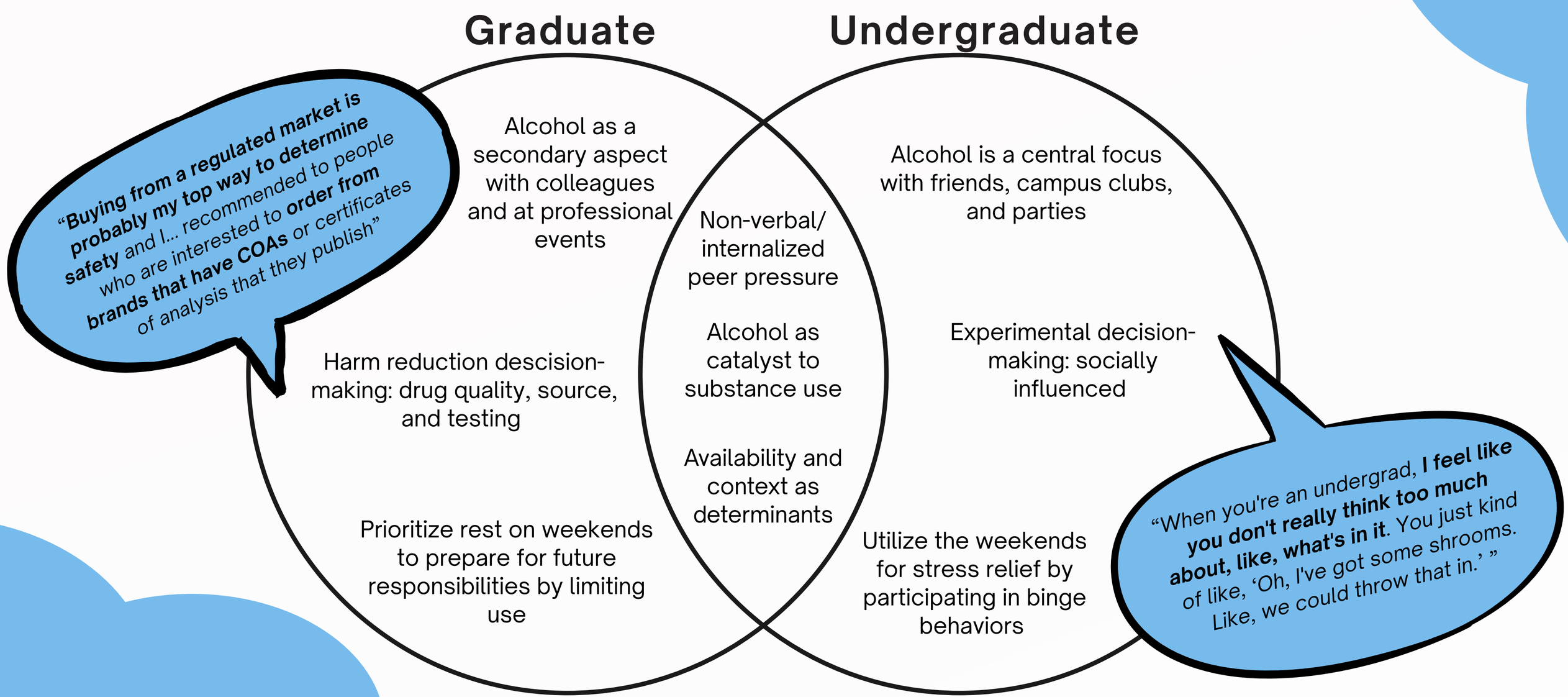








Undergraduate vs Graduate

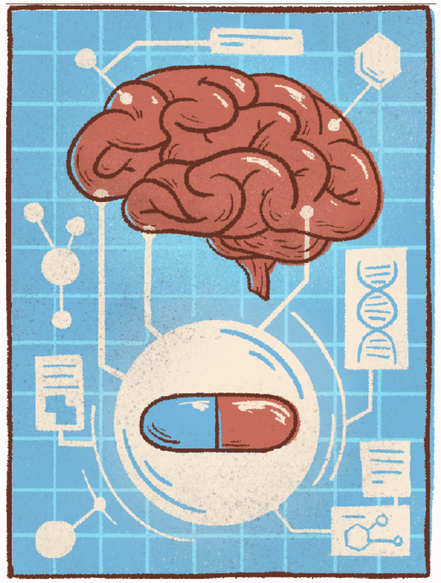


While similarities between undergraduate and graduate students are present, they manifest in different ways

	Graduate Students	*Undergraduate Students*
	Pressure due to comfortability	**Pressure due to competition**
Internalized/Non-Verbal Pressure	*I feel like, historically, for me,* ***it wouldn't even be like any sort of verbal component...****no one would be like, Come on, why aren't you drinking? But it would often just be like, being around other people who are doing it made me, like, from my own personal internal perception,* ***feel uncomfortable if I wasn't doing it,*** *which then, like, turned into,* ***itching to do it,*** *if that makes sense.*	*I feel like a lot of it is self-imposed, you know,* ***wanting to keep up with your other friends.*** *If you are having one drink, you see that they're already on to their second or third then it's like,* ***'oh, I need to keep up with that.***
		Well, you know, like, I didn't want to be the only guy who didn't, ***but I also want to be the first guy who did.***
		...you can tell they're trying to ***one-up each other****, and each one wants to be the* ***coolest guy there***

While similarities between undergraduate and graduate students are present, they manifest in different ways

	Graduate Students	*Undergraduate Students*
	Prioritize discression based on the group	**Prioritize accesibility in the given location**
Context-Based Decision Making	*I feel like with nicotine,* ***sometimes it's about like being discreet****...So if you're at, like, a conference and you're drinking with colleagues, I've seen* ***people use Zyns or like, go to the bathroom and vape, as opposed to a cigarette,*** *versus like, if they're like, out, you know, with your friends at a bar and you're sitting outside, the same people will, like smoke a cigarette....* ***depends on who is around you, like if your advisors there,*** *you don't want to pull out a cigarette.*	*[Marijuana] is kind of more common in undergrad just because, like, the availability. Yeah,* ***you get it very easily on Franklin Street*** *compared to, like, cocaine for example* *When I wanted to get high,* ***I would do whatever it took. Like I found a bag of weed in the parking lot outside my apartment, and I smoked it...****like looking back, it's like, I don't understand how I'm still alive with some of the stuff that I did, but I also recognize how problematic it was,* ***but I didn't care****.*



Recommendations



Participant Recommendations

Expand UNC's Harm Reduction Infrastructure

Include realistic information about substances and mixing them with alcohol

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Normalize harm reduction language/tools and peer safety culture

Shift to harm reduction-oriented education

Update the first year/transfer student orientation alcohol modules to include other substances

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Teach practical strategies for safer use, not abstinence

Strengthen safety-based approaches

Maintain and expand non-criminalizing/diversion programs and resources

Our Recommendations

Interrupt the Alcohol → Polysubstance Use Escalation

Shift messaging to focus on decision-making after drinking begins and risk increases

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Not “don’t do drugs” but “inhibition drops when you’re 3 drinks in”

Incorporate this framing into first year and transfer student orientation

Make Harm Reduction the Default

Increase Naloxone and drug test strip access in high-visibility student areas

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Normalize carrying harm reduction tools as routine behavior

Embed harm reduction into standard campus practices and expectations

Shift the Social Norms Around Polysubstance Use

Communicate that students are **not** regularly mixing substances

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Leverage peer influencers to model lower-risk behavior

THANK YOU

Questions?

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

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